

Report on the outcomes of a Short-Term Scientific Mission¹

Action number: CA19133 - Fostering and Strengthening Approaches to Reducing Coercion in European Mental Health Services (FOSTREN)

Grantee name: Enric Garcia Torrents

Details of the STSM

Title: Brief ethnographic fieldwork exploring alternatives to coercion in mental health care at Trieste with Dr. Tommaso Bonavigo

Start and end date: 01/08/2022 to 31/08/2022

Description of the work carried out during the STSM

Description of the activities carried out during the STSM. Any deviations from the initial working plan shall also be described in this section.

The ethnographic fieldwork at the city of Trieste, home of the psychiatric reform initiated by Dr. Franco Basaglia, took place as planned and surpassed expectations in terms of learnings on how to implement alternative practices to reduce coercion. Most of the experience was by the hand of Dr. Tommaso Bonavigo, leading psychiatrist at one of the centers of the Dipartimento di Salute Mentale (DSM, Department of Mental Health), who introduced me to his own way of practicing psychiatry, that of the nurses of the center, and the whole mental health organization of the region: home visits, dialogue with patients and their network, daily group dialogues and supervisions at the center between the professionals, interaction with social cooperatives to engage and (re)integrate mental health service users in the economic life of the community, and the use of other devices to ensure the use of minimal coercive measures while maximizing the chances of recovery.

During the stay I also enjoyed the chance to read materials from the archives of the psychiatric reform, delving into the democratic psychiatry movement that made the psychiatric reform in Italy possible, including the closure of the mental health asylum of Trieste, the passing of the historical law 180 (law Basaglia) that kickstarted the move from a system based on locking up patients in mental health hospitals to community based services in Italy, enjoying as well the chance and honor of interviewing and chatting with historical figures such as Dr. Franco Rottelli (continuator of the reform after the death of Franco Basaglia, former director general of the Azienda Sanitaria di Trieste), Dr.

¹ This report is submitted by the grantee to the Action MC for approval and for claiming payment of the awarded grant. The Grant Awarding Coordinator coordinates the evaluation of this report on behalf of the Action MC and instructs the GH for payment of the Grant.

Roberto Mezzina (ex-Director of the Dipartimento di Salute Mentale of Trieste, and leader of the WHO Collaborating Centre for Research and Training), and a member of the team that uncovered took part in the closure of the asylum in Trieste and that of the facilities at the island of Leros, one of the biggest and most horrific episodes of psychiatric neglect in recent history at the European Union level.

On top of it all there were many chances to explore and get involved in the city life, and the activities undertaken by cooperatives and projects old and new linked with the psychiatric reform like the Accademia della Follia (a theatre company run by users and professionals alike exploring the margins between normality and madness), a youth respite house, and a recently reopened house offering a space to eat, gather and play sports to all Triestans and visitors (the Casa del Popolo, located at the former Italian Communist Party headquarters in the city).

No major deviations to the initial plan to be noted, other than being complemented by autonomous research and exploration of the city, its history, and the community itself through other practices other than the public mental health services, which helped Immensely to get a better picture of the sociocultural and political context in which the psychiatric reform arose, and the reasons why it happened in Trieste in the first place.

Description of the STSM main achievements and planned follow-up activities

Description and assessment of whether the STSM achieved its planned goals and expected outcomes, including specific contribution to Action objective and deliverables, or publications resulting from the STSM. Agreed plans for future follow-up collaborations shall also be described in this section.

The STSM was an effective way to understand the model of mental health care of Trieste, at the forefront of non-coercive practices and thus perfectly aligned with the main goal of the COST action, devoted to foster alternatives to coercion in mental health practices through the European Union. The insights collected in the fieldwork are already being shared in a chapter of a new edition of a book published by Springer and edited by the European Association on Psychiatric Violence (EviPRG), were partially shared in raw form at a conference in Perugia right after finishing the fieldwork (ISPS “Co-Constructing Healing Spaces” conference), and will be further shared and used in the context of the Working Groups of the COST FOSTREN action, my own teaching activities in Spain and abroad, and other deliverables to come such a study following up the cases that I had the chance to learn about during the stay, and other projects such an action-research cooperation between the Centre for Research and Training in Trieste and an ongoing, still in planning stages, research project to evaluate potential improvements in the regional Catalan mental health system commissioned by the local authorities of my own region of origin (Catalonia, Spain).

Other follow-up activities will include a blog post on the Accademia della Follia to be posted at the Spanish site of the Mad In America network, one of the main online outlets devoted to psychiatric reform, the publication in Spanish and English of commented translations of the Law 180 and that of 2012 devoted to penal psychiatric cases, as well as a study on the experience of those involved both in the closure of the asylums in Leros and Trieste, if there is a chance to reconnect and take this deliverable forward. In any case I am planning to delve deeper in the accounts of all persons who were reintegrated into the community after the closure of the local asylum in Trieste, the few isolated cases in which the reintegration proved unfeasible, and those isolated ones in which the reintegration proved conflictive and ended up in penal cases due to violent acts and other severe problems.

All in all there is a will to strengthen the links created during the STSM to further understand the model and help implement it into other regions, helping reduce coercion in practices that so far have not benefited from the learnings and benefits ripped by the Triestian experience, still at the forefront of psychiatric and community based mental health healing innovation. In this regard, a paper summarizing

the stay, as well as stating practical, achievable recommendations applicable to other regions, will be completed and send to publication in a open-access peer-reviewed journal yet to be decided in the near future, and shared with all members of the COST FOSTREN action, thus contributing to the action goal of identifying and collectively helping implement better mental health practices.